information in the world grows, we can expect the flood of information to expose the occasional lies and errors and to ultimately provide us with a more truthful understanding of the world.

On this crucial point, this book strongly disagrees with the naive view. There certainly are instances of information that attempt to represent reality and succeed in doing so, but this is *not* the defining characteristic of information. A few pages ago I referred to stars as information and casually mentioned astrologers alongside astronomers. Adherents of the naive view of information probably squirmed in their chairs when they read it. According to the naive view, astronomers derive 'real information' from the stars, while the information that astrologers imagine to read in constellations is either 'misinformation' or 'disinformation'. If only people were given more information about the universe, surely they would abandon astrology altogether. But the fact is that for thousands of years astrology has had a huge impact on history, and today millions of people still check their star signs before making the most important decisions of their lives, like what to study and whom to marry. As of 2021, the global astrology market was valued at $12.8 billion.[8]

No matter what we think about the accuracy of astrological information, we should acknowledge its important role in history. It has connected lovers, and even entire empires. Roman emperors routinely consulted astrologers before making decisions. Indeed, astrology was held in such high esteem that casting the horoscope of a reigning emperor was a capital offence. Presumably, anyone casting such a horoscope could foretell when and how the emperor would die.[9] Rulers in some countries still take astrology very seriously. In 2005 the junta of Myanmar allegedly moved the country's capital from Yangon to Naypyidaw based on astrological advice.[10] A theory of information that cannot account for the historical significance of astrology is clearly inadequate.

What the example of astrology illustrates is that errors, lies, fantasies and fictions are information, too. Contrary to what the naive view of information says, information has no essential link to truth, and its role in history isn't to represent a pre-existing reality. Rather, what information does is to create *new* realities by tying together disparate things – whether couples or empires. Its defining feature is connection rather than representation, and information is whatever connects different points into a network. Information doesn't necessarily inform us about things. Rather, it